towards each other, irrespective of nationality, governments and states would become largely irrelevant. Gandhi argues in the end for a global order built on small, self-sufficient communities – village republics – with only a loose relationship to central governments.

Great Power

The third Indian worldview is of India as a Great Power. India has been shy talking about itself in grandiose power terms. Virtually all Indian references to India as a Great Power are qualified, the most frequent being the qualifier 'rising'. Prime Minister Narendra Modi and External Affairs Minister Jaishankar have stopped using the term 'rising power' to describe India but do not go further than to refer to India as a 'leading power' – even though deep down they may believe it should (will) be a hegemonic *vishwaguru* or 'world teacher'. The Indian strategist Bharat Karnad, the most outspoken proponent of India's Great Power destiny, titles his book *Why India Is Not a Great Power (Yet)*. The title gestures towards the inevitability of India as a Great Power but admits it is not in the top bracket. The sense that India will inevitably be a Great Power is widespread among the chattering classes. Pratap Bhanu Mehta, the political theorist, summarizes the inevitability view: 'Almost by virtue of her population, resources, and location, India would be a great power; if India were to be left free to be itself, greatness would come to it. But it would be a greatness that would not depend on the projection of power . . . it would be a great power without global objectives.'[91]

India's first prime minister had little doubt that India was already, or would become, a Great Power and not just for the reasons of population, resources, and location. India, for Nehru, is uniquely a bridge and a crossroads, culturally, politically, and geopolitically. With its Islamic cultural heritage, it links to the Gulf and Middle East and other Muslim societies. With its Buddhist past, it connects to Southeast and Northeast Asia. And its Hinduism is a bond to its South Asian neighbours and to